

THE KESTREL OF LANTERN- FALL

Fourth Wall Gaming

CHAPTER ONE — THE LAST SUPPER



There is a kind of light that only the dying make, and the lamps of Lanternfall made it best of all.

They burned along the western face of the spire in their thousands, ring above ring, each one tended by a hand that climbed the bone-walks at dusk and again at dawn — a constellation hung on a corpse, for the spire was the carcass of some sky-leviathan dead a thousand years, and the Alar lived in its hollows the way mites live in a fallen whale. Sefa Rocksquill had flown under those lamps all her service and never once thought them sad until the evening she killed the drake, and understood at last what they were for. They were not there to push back the dark. They were there to call the starving in out of it.

She was Vael, kestrel-kin, narrow through the shoulder and quick in the wing, with the russet barring of her people across her primaries and a temper she wore like a second harness. At dusk on the night this account begins she was flying the lamp-patrol of the fourth ring, idle and bored, watching the lamp-tenders move their small fires from wick to wick — and she saw the haze to the east bunch and fold the way air folds around something large that does not want to be seen.

A drake. A windlane hunter, all leather and appetite, riding the dead currents in off the empty east. It had not seen her.

She did the thing her people are made for and her commander would later call stupid: she folded her wings and fell on it out of the

high amber, wingspear couched, and drove the point down through the root of its left wing before it knew the sky held a second predator. What followed was not glorious. Glory is a story told afterward by those who were not bitten. The drake screamed and tumbled and tore itself off her spear and crashed twelve metres onto the lamp-ring scaffold, ruining its other wing on the bone; her hatchet rang off its skull and did nothing; her spear would not come free no matter how she set her boot and hauled, and she spent her luck on the hauling and the luck did nothing either. Then the thing got its jaws around her left arm and *held*, and threw its whole dying weight over the rim of the world to drag her down into the deep sky with it.

She broke its grip with a wrench of pure animal refusal — a roll of the bones so perfect the gamblers would have wept — and the wing-membrane tore off her spear-point and the drake fell away alone, turning, growing small, swallowed by the haze it had come out of. Her spear she kept. Her arm she would feel for a week.

When the company medic came and cut the blood-stiff harness off her, he turned the drake's measure over in his head and frowned. *Thin under the hide*, he said. *Third eastern stray this month. They don't come here because here is good — they come because the east is empty. Starving things come to the light.* He pressed the dressing flat against the bite and looked at her almost kindly. *You did it a kindness.*

A lamp-tender on the scaffold, an old Vael with soot to her elbows, said it plainer, to no one: *The east haze used to sing with skimmers at dusk. Been quiet since the thaw.*

Sefa flew in to make her report with her arm splinted to her ribs and the first thread of the thing already snagged in her, though she did not yet know it had a shape. She thought she had killed a hungry animal. She had, in fact, met the first ambassador of the silence that was eating the world, and mistaken it for weather.

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Commander Esk Veil-Torn drafted fliers, not invalids, and said so. She stood at her survey table with the eastern charts already pinned and

already wrong, dead-air flags clustered along the old lane like a rash, and she looked at Sefa's splint and offered her three days' rest or the dawn launch and the honesty to choose between them.

"Sooner is better," Sefa said. "Wouldn't you say, commander."

So at next light she met her wing-partner on the eastern launch ledge: Kithrel of the Moul't, the fastest survey-flier on the muster, a Greywake survivor who wore eleven lane-tokens braided into her primaries for a dead flight she would not speak of, and who charted the margins of the still zones tighter than any regulation allowed because — the mess said, and the mess was right — she was not measuring the dead air. She was daring it.

Out to the Veyl shallows, Kithrel said, setting the terms the way she set everything, precisely and without warmth. *I read the air, you watch the sky. When I say we turn, we turn. The edge doesn't negotiate.*

I'll try to keep up, Sefa told her, and meant it as a joke, and found within the hour that it was not one.

They flew east into a quiet that thickened as they went. The living wind died around them by degrees, the way a fever breaks in reverse — and fifteen kilometres out, where the lane should have hummed with skim-shoals at the turn of the morning, Sefa saw pale shapes standing on a skim-reef in the haze, and could not make them out, and Kithrel, who had flown this lane for nine years, looked once and breathed: *That is none of them. Nine years on this lane, and that is none of them.*

They came in high and offset, on the agreed terms — *first gust of anything wrong, we climb and run west* — and at four hundred metres Kithrel's aneroid stopped reading a number at all.

Zero, she said. Her voice had gone strange. *Not low. Zero. There is no breath in this air at all. The still zone isn't out at the shallows. It's here.*

On the reef stood nine figures in wax-bleached robes, evenly spaced, facing east, singing low and together — the Hushed Choir, that cult which had decided the dying of the wind was not a calamity but a sabbath, the world at last breathing in. They did not turn for the fliers. They did not turn for anything. And drifting among them,

translucent and slow, were the things the dead air grows when it has been let alone too long: pale bells the size of a crouching man, going from singer to singer, settling over the upturned faces, and drinking.

The pair withdrew to a reef-knuckle a kilometre and a half west of the zero line, behind the bone-spine, and set a courier's picket with the light at their backs, because dead air is one-way ground and only a fool flies into it without first marking the door. *This is where we cover each other*, Sefa said, *in case the deal goes bad*. And they watched, because watching was the order, while the Choir went from nine voices to seven and the bells went from seven to nine — splitting as they fed, multiplying on the breath of the willing dead.

After the second singer was drunk dry without so much as a stumble in the chord, Sefa had seen enough to know the rest without counting it.

Head home, she said. *We don't need to count them to know what's going to happen. Next we find the ones who sent these fools out here to die. Fly quiet and fly safe.*

It was the right order. It would cost her a wing. The narrator, who knows the shape of these things, would tell her so if telling ever changed anything; it does not.

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What follows is the part of the tale that has no dice in it and decides everything anyway.

The threads ran back into the under-city, into the marrow-galleries and the wax-houses and the counter-stalls where the gallery-poor sold each other secrets at a discount. A foreman at Orrim's Pale-Vats had run night-shift white work at scale in early spring — nine bodies' worth of wax — taken from a soft-spoken hooded Vael who smelled of shrine-incense and paid over the odds without haggling, and the nine bundles had gone *down*, into the condemned bone-galleries beneath the windlane approach. And the beggars who slept in the under-stair knew of a quiet supper held there every ninth night: robed folk, candles, in the sealed dark. The next was tomorrow.

The foreman's name was Bele Tarrow, and Sefa went to him not with the Commander's writ but with her empty hands.

She found him at a counter-house called the Tallow Cup between the first bell and the second, a big Roak gone soft in the shoulders, grey at the crest, guarding a bowl he was not eating. He sat with his back to the wall and his eye on the door, which is not how an innocent man takes his breakfast. On his thick wrist he wore a child's tally-bead bracelet, old, worn smooth, and he touched it without knowing he did.

She had a charter in her pocket that would have compelled him to answer. She read his face instead — the fear that came from below the stair and not from the guild above, the grief he was already wearing for something not yet lost — and she put the charter away.

"Is everyone okay?" she asked him, low, the voice she'd use on a fledgling stranded on a ledge. "Anything I could help you with, Bele Tarrow?"

And the clean twenty-year foreman came apart at the seams, quietly, the way big men do.

His daughter. Derra, a vat-clerk on his own floor, the best tally-hand in the works, who had gone silent at Winterend and then gone *Hushed*, the dead air growing soft around her like wool over the world. A soft-spoken Vael with clean hands and the smell of lamp-oil and coin had found him at shift's end and given him a sentence he now recited the way a man recites a knot that holds his life: *The silence is not a sickness, foreman. It is an arrival. She will be honoured among us, and you may pay her keeping like any loving father pays a dowry.*

So he paid. Bread and water-jugs and mooring rope, ninth-night by ninth-night, off his own tally, left at the third side-mouth past the under-stair. He had seen her once, at Solstice, let to stand at a curtain and watch her straighten mats. *She looked kept*, he said. *That's all I can say. Kept.*

And nine days ago the asking had changed. Not bread now. Rope, in quantity. And lamp-oil — four casks, and four more tonight.

They sit in the dark down there, Tarrow said. They love the dark. So what does a congregation that doesn't light lamps want with that much oil?

Sefa gave him the truth, because he had earned it and because she could not stand to leave him with the lie. "Those people who say they're tending people with the stillness — they're tending the stillness itself"

He nodded as though she'd named a thing he had carried alone for a long time. *I know. I knew when they asked for the rope.* His hands found the bracelet again. *You don't need rope to tend the sick.*

He told her the rest in pieces — that the soft man gave the orders and a woman with a cantor's lilt and a big quiet one deferred to him; that three ninth-nights past the soft man had worn a new pin at his collar, small worked bone in the shape of a closed hand. A rendering man knows worked bone. *Featherwright craft*, Tarrow said. *Guild quality.* The closed hand of the Featherwrights — the wing-wrights and bone-joiners whose guild-oath was *no one falls*.

Somewhere under the stair a man of that guild, a wing-surgeon sworn to hold the broken off the long drop, had decided that the kindest making left was a clean death — and had dressed it as a mercy so that the grieving would carry the fuel down for him.

Tarrow rose for his shift. At the door he turned back and gave her the only thing he had to give. *My girl, Warden. Whatever you're doing down there. My girl.*

The Commander, when the threads were laid before her, named the cult's true work in a single breath. They were not worshipping in the bones of her spire — forty metres under her own launch ledge. They were *cultivating*: housing the Hushed and the bells together in one room, feeding the dead air on the breath of the willing until it spread. They had not built a shrine. They had built an engine, and parked it at the throat of the only way in or out of Lanternfall.

Watch, don't raid, Esk ordered. *Spring a trap and I get nine more fools while the tailor walks. Bring me a face.* She took a Warden falchion

from the chart-room rack and put it in Sefa's hand. *Bring it back with a story or don't bother bringing it back.*

Sefa took it with a kestrel-kin's quiet prayer, drew a throwing hatchet, and racked her wingspear as too long for the corridors of the dead. Then she went down into the dark to keep a watch, and the watch, like all the orders of that night, would not survive contact with the thing it was meant to observe.

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They split at the gallery mouth: Kithrel in the shadow there with three flares and the Commander's runner, and Sefa up into the vault of the supper-room itself, climbing the old Marrower scaffold on half-furled wings because in dead air a wing bites only half of nothing and the other half it shoves about the room like a held breath let go. She folded onto the high perch in the dark and became part of the bone, and watched the room wake.

The keeper came first — a flat-feathered Vael with a burn-scar on the web of one thumb, twenty-two years a lampwright before the silence took her, lighting the tallow now in a slow chain down the half-circle of mats, tending the room the way she had once tended a lamp-walk, forever, in the dark. Then the grieving: six families, ordinary and ruined, taking the mats like mourners taking pews. Then the Hushed, led not driven, flat-feathered and wing-wrong, the tallow-flames leaning and guttering as the dead air came in with them — and among them a small ink-stained figure with a vat-clerk's hands and her father's jaw and nothing at all behind her open eyes. Derra Tarrow, straightening nothing now.

And last, through the felt-hung arch, the three who ran the thing: a big silent Ossuin who took post by the oil-casks; a living cantor in grey with an ash-censer swinging; and between them, unhurried, a soft-faced Vael with clean hands and a small closed hand of bone at his collar. *The Mercy.* Vesh.

He lifted his empty palms to the mats and spoke in the warm, carrying, bedside voice of a man who has delivered bad news to the frightened all his life and learned to make it sound like love.

“Friends. You’ve fed them faithfully, and they’ve grown. Tonight they’re ready to give back what the world gave them — and you’ll have your beloveds returned to the air they came from. All of you. Tonight is the last supper. After this, no one need pay again.”

The lifter put a hand on a cask.

Sefa’s hatchet was already turning in her fingers. She threw it — a sooted blur out of the high dark — and buried it in the lifter’s cask-wrist, and the oil-tongue choked off, and every amber-lit face in the room tipped up toward a perch that had held nothing a heartbeat before.

Vesh produced a spark-striker over the spilled oil with a conjuror’s ease, and found her in the dark, and did not crank it. Not yet. Villains who have made a philosophy of murder cannot resist explaining it first; it is the one mercy the gods grant their victims.

“A Warden. Of course.” His thumb rested on the wheel. “Come down, feather — you don’t want to be up there when this room goes to sleep. There’s no flying in dead air. And there’s no flying at all once I turn my wrist.”

She gave him a show, because a show was time, and time was Kithrel marshalling the door. She rose to her height and rang the falchion out of its sheath and threw her voice down like a stone: *You’re surrounded, surgeon — the whole draft’s in these galleries!* It was a lie, and he had spent thirty years reading the pitch at which the frightened lie.

“No,” he said, almost gently. “There are no other wings. I’d have heard them. This air carries a lie better than it carries a flock.”

But the lie missed him and struck the families instead. She had named the casks aloud, in front of the people who had carried them down, and a grey-crested young Lanhawk on the mats said into the

silence, *Vesh. He said it was a blessing. He said our daughter would only*

The room turned under the Mercy like a deck. He sent his bleeding lifter toward the arch and kept the striker, and Sefa stopped wasting breath on him.

To the flares! she roared at the families, the full launch-deck of her lungs behind it. *Go — the wing's at the door!*

They broke. Terror did what her stalling could not, and they scrambled for the mouth where Kithrel's first flare was already climbing, a hard red star to steer by. And Sefa folded her wings and fell — nine metres, straight down out of the dark, falchion leading, the kestrel's dive she had been born for.

The dead air nearly killed her with it. Her wings found their half of nothing at the bottom and the dive came wrong, the falchion's arc opening on empty, and the soft man simply leaned a hand's-width aside as a screaming Warden plummeted past his shoulder — and his thumb finished its work on the wheel.

She wrenched the fall back onto its line with the last luck the gods would lend her, and the falchion came home. It went through the root of his left wing and did not stop — bone and sinew and the great flight-muscle — and the Mercy's wing came away to hang by a wet hand's-breadth of skin, and the architect of all that gentle slaughter folded to the floor with the closed-hand pin winking once in the tallow-light. Maimed by exactly the logic he had sold to grieving fathers. There is a justice in such symmetries, and it is never, ever enough.

His striker had thrown its spark on the way down.

The room took a breath of fire. It ran out from where he fell in two bright tongues — one along the swept path toward the mats, one curling back toward the four casks — and the dead air that had eaten every whisper all night did nothing to fire at all, only sat and let it climb. The Hushed recoiled from the light, rooted and shuddering, and among them Derra Tarrow's dead eyes caught the glare.

Sefa took up the dying Vesh to haul him out — the face the Commander wanted — and then the nearest cask began to sing its rising kettle-shriek, and she did the thing no rule predicts. She rammed the surgeon's body into the cask to take the blast and threw herself the other way, toward the girl. The barrel burst against the corpse and most of it spent itself there; the rest caught her half-turned and picked her up and flung her, and when she came down at Derra's feet there was fire in the feathers of her left wing and it was burning.

And the fire ducked. In the three-metre hush that wrapped the silent girl, the flames guttered and starved on the dead air — the same nothing that was killing the world, refusing for one absurd instant to feed. The thing that had taken Derra was the only reason Sefa was not a torch. It cost her every breath; her chest filled with flat, lifeless air that gave nothing back.

Grounded, her wing a ruin, no luck and no lift, she gathered the girl against her and held what breath she had and ran — fifteen metres of fire toward a red star, on the only thing a Gale Warden owns when the wings are gone, which is her loyalty to the draft and the one law beneath it: *leave no one*.

She made it most of the way. Then her held breath turned to a fist in her chest and her legs stopped believing in the floor, and she went down five metres short of the mouth with the dark closing in from every edge, Kithrel screaming her name across the roar and the rescue-line uncoiling toward her outstretched hand.

She did not take it for herself. She looped it around the girl and shoved Derra the last terrible distance into her partner's reach — *Got her — I've got her!* — and the hush went out of the room on the rope with the child, and the fire remembered Sefa was there, and the dark she had been fighting all night finally won and took her down into it.

Kithrel dropped the line and went back into the fire for her, because the creed cuts both ways, and dragged her clear as a second cask blew the supper-room to ash behind them.

She woke on the cold bone of the gallery floor with real air sawing into her lungs, the sweetest thing she had ever breathed, and her

partner's two fists knotted in her harness. The families were out, huddled and coughing and alive. Derra stood among them, silent and dead-eyed and *out*. Behind the curtain the last supper ate itself, Vesh in it, the cult's engine and its housed dead going up into a new scar of still air under the spire — and on this side of the fire, six families breathed, and a father's girl stood waiting to be carried home.

There she is, Kithrel said, wrecked and almost laughing. *There she is, you stubborn squill. I went in for you. Cask went off behind us — you owe me a drink.*

Sefa sat up and looked at her wing. The flight-feathers were crisped to black quills, the membrane scorched stiff, the whole of it hanging wrong — a flier's worst sentence, written across her own back by a guild wing-surgeon who had made a gospel of mercy, and who had burned with the room he'd meant to be a pyre for everyone in it. She looked at it a long moment. Then she turned to her partner and shook her head and said the only word that fit.

"Fuck."

"Yeah," Kithrel agreed. "That about covers it."

She had asked, that morning, to be told when she got to do something satisfying. She gestured at the dying fire, at the ash that had been a man, at the burned ruin of her own wing, and gave her verdict on the night's work: *This wasn't it. This was the opposite of it. This was deeply, profoundly unsatisfying.*

But six families walked up out of the bone-galleries into the thin grey of true dawn, and a Hushed girl walked among them on the living side of the fire, and somewhere a closed hand of worked bone still moved in the high guild-halls of the Featherwrights, attached to a question no one had yet thought to ask. The wind was still dying. The kestrel could not fly. And the lamps of Lanternfall burned on along the western face, calling the starving in out of the dark, the way they always had, the way — the narrator knows, and lets the dread leak in — they always would.

Let's go home, Kith.

Yeah. The hand under her bad side, taking the weight without being asked. *Let's go home.*